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Expense & Equipment Policy

1. Scope and principles

This policy applies in full to Westline staff. Contractors are covered by section 6, which lists what a contractor may claim, and by section 8, which covers tax and payroll when working outside your home province. Creator partners are covered by section 7 only, which describes invoicing; the rest of this document describes a commercial relationship creator partners are not in, and reading it will give a creator partner the wrong answer. See HANDBOOK section 2.

Three principles govern everything below. Westline pays for costs incurred to do Westline work, and not for costs you would have had anyway. Approval comes before the spend, not after. Every claim carries an itemised receipt, and a credit-card statement line is not a receipt.

2. Approval limits

2.1 By amount

Approval authority is set by the total amount of the commitment, not by the size of an individual receipt. Splitting a purchase to stay under a limit is a policy breach regardless of intent.

Under two hundred and fifty dollars is self-approved by any staff member. From two hundred and fifty to one thousand dollars requires newsroom lead approval. From one thousand to five thousand dollars requires market director approval. Above five thousand dollars requires the finance director.

2.2 Pre-approval

Travel, equipment purchases, software subscriptions, and any commitment above one thousand dollars are pre-approved in writing before the commitment is made. A claim for an unapproved commitment may be declined in full, and the person who made the commitment carries it.

2.3 Submission deadline

Claims are submitted within forty-five days of the date the cost was incurred. Claims older than forty-five days require finance director approval and are frequently declined. Reimbursement is paid on the next payroll cycle after approval.

3. Travel

3.1 Booking

Travel between markets is booked through the Westline travel desk. Air travel is economy class on any flight under five hours. Rail is preferred over air where the journey time is comparable. Where a staff member chooses a more expensive option for personal reasons, Westline reimburses the cost of the standard option and the difference is the traveller's.

Travel to another Westline market for your own convenience is not a business trip and nothing is reimbursable. REMOTE section 2.2 explains the distinction: if your lead asked you to be there it is a trip, and if you asked to be there it is your trip.

3.2 Per diems

Meals on a business trip are covered by a per diem rather than by receipts. The per diem is set by the market you are travelling to.

Calgary is sixty-five dollars per day. Edmonton is sixty-five dollars per day. Vancouver is seventy-five dollars per day. Kelowna is sixty dollars per day. Saskatoon is fifty-eight dollars per day. Winnipeg is fifty-eight dollars per day. Any other destination in Canada is sixty-five dollars per day. International destinations are set per trip by Finance before departure.

Per diems are pro-rated for partial days at one quarter for breakfast, one third for lunch and the balance for dinner, and are reduced by any meal provided by a host, a conference or an airline.

3.3 Accommodation

Accommodation is booked through the travel desk at a nightly cap of one hundred and eighty dollars before tax, and two hundred and twenty dollars before tax in Vancouver. Staying with friends or family instead of a hotel is reimbursed at fifty dollars per night with no receipt required.

3.4 Ground transport

Mileage in a personal vehicle is reimbursed at sixty-two cents per kilometre, which includes fuel, insurance and wear. Parking and tolls are reimbursed with receipts. Taxis and ride-hailing are reimbursed where transit is impractical, unsafe, or where you are carrying equipment. Vehicle rental requires lead approval and is booked through the travel desk.

3.5 Changes and emergencies

Change fees are reimbursed where the change was required by Westline, by a news event, or by a bereavement occurring while travelling. Change fees for personal convenience are not reimbursed. Travel to a funeral is a personal cost and is not reimbursable under this policy; LEAVE section 3.3 says the same thing from the leave side.

4. Home office

Staff working from home under REMOTE receive a one-time home office allowance of five hundred dollars for a desk, a chair, a monitor or a keyboard, claimable after the first day of employment and not before. A recurring allowance of two hundred and fifty dollars per calendar year covers replacement and consumables, and does not accumulate if unused.

Internet and mobile service at home are not reimbursed for staff, on the basis that these are costs

you would have anyway. Where a role requires a specific upgrade, such as a guaranteed upload rate for live contribution, the incremental cost is reimbursed with market director approval.

Home office items purchased under this allowance are Westline property above two hundred and fifty dollars in value, are recorded on the equipment register, and are returned under ONBOARD section 6.2.

5. Equipment purchases for staff

Staff do not buy their own production equipment. Cameras, lenses, audio kits, lighting, drones and computers are issued by Westline against an equipment record under ONBOARD section 3.1, and are Westline property.

Where a role genuinely needs equipment Westline has not issued, raise it with your lead as an equipment request rather than buying it and claiming it back. A staff member who buys production equipment without pre-approval under section 2.2 has bought it personally, and Westline will not reimburse it after the fact.

Personal phones used for content capture attract an allowance of forty dollars per month for staff in field roles, which covers the wear and the data. The phone remains the staff member's own. INFOSEC section 5 governs what must happen to material captured on it.

Software subscriptions are procured centrally. A personal subscription to an editing or design tool is not reimbursable, because Westline holds licences for the approved tools and a personal subscription creates a licence and a security exposure at once.

6. What contractors may claim

6.1 Claimable

A contractor may claim, where the engagement letter provides for it and the cost was pre-approved in writing by the engaging producer: travel between markets at Westline's request, on the same booking rules as section 3.1; per diems at the section 3.2 rates for days spent travelling at Westline's request; mileage at sixty-two cents per kilometre; parking, tolls and transit for assignment travel; media accreditation and event passes required by an assignment; and location permits and fees required by an assignment.

6.2 Not claimable

A contractor may not claim equipment of any kind, including cameras, lenses, drones, audio kit, computers and phones. A contractor is an independent business and the tools of that business are the contractor's own capital cost, recoverable through the day rate rather than through this policy.

Also not claimable: software and cloud subscriptions; insurance, including equipment insurance and liability insurance, which the engagement may require the contractor to carry; professional memberships and training; meals on a day that did not involve travel at Westline's request; and travel between home and a regular place of work.

6.3 How a contractor claims

Claimable costs are invoiced with the engagement invoice, not through the staff expense system,

with itemised receipts attached and the assignment reference on each line. Payment follows the engagement letter's terms.

7. Creator partner invoicing

7.1 What this section is

This is the only section of this policy that applies to creator partners. It describes what a creator partner may invoice Westline for. Sections 2 through 6 describe staff and contractor arrangements and do not apply, which matters most for section 5: section 5 says Westline issues equipment to staff, and a creator partner reading it might conclude that Westline funds creator equipment. It does not.

7.2 Equipment is the creator partner's own

Westline does not reimburse, subsidise, co-fund or buy back equipment purchased by a creator partner. Cameras, lenses, drones, gimbals, lighting, audio kit, computers, phones and software subscriptions bought by a creator partner are the creator partner's own property, purchased with the creator partner's own money, and they remain the creator partner's property when the agreement ends.

There is no approval route that changes this and no amount of pre-approval that makes an equipment purchase reimbursable. A creator partner who buys a drone for a Westline shoot has bought a drone. CREATOR section 7.1 states the same rule from the programme side, and CREATOR section 7.2 describes the loaner equipment pool, which is the intended answer when a brief needs kit the creator partner does not own.

The one adjacent case worth naming: a short-term rental of equipment for a specific commissioned shoot is a production cost and can be an allowance line under section 7.3, where an outright purchase of the same item cannot. The distinction is that the rental ends with the shoot and the purchase does not.

7.3 What may be invoiced

A creator partner invoices two things and no others. First, the base segment rate for the commissioned deliverable, at the tier stated in the Creator Partner Agreement and set out in the rate card at CREATOR section 1.3. Second, a production allowance for costs incurred making that specific commissioned segment, up to the tier ceiling, and only where the commissioning brief budgeted the allowance before the shoot.

Allowable production costs include location fees and permits, a hired second operator for the day, equipment rental for the shoot, licensed music, travel that the brief specifically requires, and insurance required by a location. They do not include the creator partner's ordinary cost of doing business: transport within the home market, meals, general insurance, accounting, and the equipment covered by section 7.2.

7.4 How to invoice

Invoice through the Creator Partnerships portal, referencing the commissioning brief number, with the base segment rate and any agreed production allowance on separate lines and receipts

attached to the allowance line. Submit within forty-five days of delivery. Westline pays Net thirty days from receipt of a complete invoice, and an invoice missing a brief number or a receipt is not complete. CREATOR section 4.3 sets out the same terms from the programme side.

7.5 Taxes

Creator partners are responsible for their own tax, and for registering for and remitting sales tax where their circumstances require it. Westline does not withhold and does not issue a T4. See CREATOR section 4.4.

8. Working outside your home province: tax and payroll

8.1 Why this section exists

Where you physically work determines which province taxes your employment income, which province's workers compensation scheme covers you, and in some cases whether Westline has a filing obligation it did not previously have. None of that follows your home market, your manager, or where your pay is deposited. It follows your feet.

This is the substance behind the approval thresholds in REMOTE section 3, and it is why an arrangement of more than four weeks outside your home province needs Finance review rather than a lead's signature.

8.2 Inside Canada

A stay of four weeks or less outside your home province does not normally change payroll withholding, and REMOTE section 3.1 allows it on a lead's sign-off. Beyond four weeks, Finance assesses whether withholding must move to the province you are working in, and whether workers compensation registration is required there. Where withholding moves, take-home pay changes, sometimes materially, and the change is not reversed when you return; it is trued up at year end.

8.3 Outside Canada

Any work outside Canada is reviewed before departure regardless of duration, under REMOTE section 3.3. Some jurisdictions attach a withholding or filing obligation from the first day of work performed there, some after a threshold of days, and some by treaty exemption that must be claimed rather than assumed. Working while on holiday abroad, even for an afternoon, can create one of these obligations, which is why REMOTE section 3.3 has no self-approved tier.

Extended presence can also create a permanent establishment exposure for Westline in the destination. That is a company-level risk that an individual cannot assess and cannot consent to, which is the reason the eight-week annual cap in REMOTE section 3.4 has no override.

8.4 Contractors

A contractor is responsible for their own tax position wherever they work, and Westline does not withhold. A contractor engaged to work outside their usual province tells the engaging producer before the engagement begins, because it may change the terms and the insurance the engagement requires.

9. Worked examples

9.1 A contractor who bought a laptop for an edit

Not claimable, per section 6.2. A contractor is an independent business and the tools of that business are the contractor's own capital cost, recovered through the day rate rather than through this policy. The same answer applies to a lens, a drone, an audio recorder and a software subscription.

What the same contractor may claim on that engagement, where the engagement letter provides for it and the cost was pre-approved in writing: travel between markets at Westline's request, per diems for the travel days at the section 3.2 rates, mileage at sixty-two cents per kilometre, parking and transit, accreditation, and location permits. Those go on the engagement invoice with receipts and the assignment reference, not through the staff expense system, per section 6.3.

9.2 A creator partner who bought a drone for a sponsored shoot

Not reimbursable, per section 7.2, and there is no approval route that changes it. The drone is the creator partner's own property and stays theirs when the agreement ends.

Three things would have worked instead, and all of them happen before the money is spent. The loaner pool at CREATOR section 7.2 supplies a drone for a commissioned shoot at no charge, booked five business days ahead. A rental for the specific shoot is a production cost and can be an allowance line under section 7.3, because a rental ends with the shoot and a purchase does not. And where the brief genuinely requires kit nobody has, the producer budgets for it in the commissioning brief before the shoot rather than after it.

Note what is not in that list: a pre-approval for a purchase. The tier ceiling in CREATOR section 1.3 is a ceiling on the production allowance, not an equipment budget, and an allowance that the brief did not budget is not payable at all.

9.3 A staff member who bought a monitor

Covered by the home office allowance in section 4, which is five hundred dollars one time plus two hundred and fifty dollars per calendar year, claimable after the first day of employment. A monitor above two hundred and fifty dollars in value is Westline property, goes on the equipment register, and is returned under ONBOARD section 6.2.

A staff member who bought a camera instead is in a different position. Production equipment is issued by Westline under section 5, not bought and claimed back, and an unapproved purchase under section 2.2 has been made personally. The route is an equipment request through the lead, before buying.

9.4 A trip to Vancouver for two nights

Booked through the travel desk, economy air under section 3.1. Accommodation to two hundred and twenty dollars before tax per night, which is the Vancouver cap under section 3.3 rather than the general one hundred and eighty. Per diem at seventy-five dollars per day under section 3.2, reduced for any meal the host or the airline provided, and pro-rated on the partial travel days. Taxis where transit is impractical or equipment is being carried, per section 3.4. Claim within forty-five days, per section 2.3.

If the same staff member had asked to work from the Vancouver office for their own convenience, nothing would be reimbursable, per section 3.1 and REMOTE section 2.2. The test is who asked.

9.5 A purchase split across two claims

A staff member commits to a fourteen hundred dollar item and submits it as two claims of seven hundred dollars each to stay inside the lead's approval limit. That is a policy breach under section 2.1 regardless of intent, because approval authority is set by the total commitment rather than by the size of an individual receipt. The correct route was market director approval before committing.

9.6 Six weeks working from Lisbon

The expense question is not the travel, which is personal and not reimbursable. It is section 8.3. Some jurisdictions attach a withholding or filing obligation from the first day of work performed there, some after a threshold of days, and some by treaty exemption that has to be claimed rather than assumed. Extended presence can also create a permanent establishment exposure for Westline, which is a company level risk an individual cannot assess or consent to on the company's behalf.

That is the substance behind REMOTE section 3.3 requiring People and Culture and Finance approval before any work outside Canada regardless of duration, and behind the eight week annual cap in REMOTE section 3.4 having no override.

9.7 A claim submitted four months later

Past the forty-five day deadline in section 2.3, so it needs finance director approval and is frequently declined. The deadline exists because expenses are accrued to the period they were incurred in, and a claim arriving after the quarter has closed has to be reopened.

10. Quick reference

10.1 Approval thresholds

Under two hundred and fifty dollars is self-approved. Two hundred and fifty to one thousand dollars needs the newsroom lead. One thousand to five thousand dollars needs the market director. Above five thousand dollars needs the finance director. Travel, equipment, subscriptions and anything above one thousand dollars are pre-approved in writing before the commitment.

10.2 Rates

Mileage is sixty-two cents per kilometre. Accommodation caps are one hundred and eighty dollars per night before tax, and two hundred and twenty in Vancouver. Staying with friends or family instead is fifty dollars per night with no receipt. Per diems are sixty-five dollars in Calgary and Edmonton, seventy-five in Vancouver, sixty in Kelowna, fifty-eight in Saskatoon and Winnipeg, and sixty-five elsewhere in Canada. The home office allowance is five hundred dollars one time plus two hundred and fifty dollars per year. The personal phone allowance for staff in field roles is forty dollars per month.

10.3 Deadlines

Staff and contractor claims are submitted within forty-five days of the cost being incurred. Creator partner invoices are submitted within forty-five days of delivery and are paid Net thirty from a

complete invoice. An invoice missing a brief number or a receipt is not complete and the clock has not started.

10.4 By class, in one line each

Staff are covered by this whole policy. Contractors are covered by section 6, which lists what they may claim, and section 8 on tax. Creator partners are covered by section 7 only, which says the base segment rate and an agreed production allowance are invoiceable and equipment never is.